crore enterprise, it became the first Indian private company to achieve a turnover of Rs 10,000 crore in 1997. The numbers revealed that the company had grown over seven times or achieved an aggregate growth of over 622 per cent from 1988 (when he took over as chairman of TELCO) to 1997.

At the 1997 AGM, a beaming chairman revealed that his next focus would be on improving quality. He added that the company has been accelerating 'product development … with a view to providing the customers with a wider range of products with higher levels of reliability and safety as well as with lower emissions'.

The Birth of India's Car

Ratan's dream of making an Indian-designed car became a reality when in January 1998, at the Delhi Auto Expo, TELCO launched India's first fully indigenous passenger car, the Tata Indica (the name was short for 'India's car'). It was a name that Ratan chose, says Dube. The majority of analysts, however, saw the project as a major gamble. There was widespread criticism and the foreign media 'ridiculed' Ratan, says Praveen Kadle, former CFO of the company.

Even in India, Ratan was virtually scorned for pursuing the idea of an Indian-designed car. It even made him wonder if he had made a mistake. Speaking about the opposition he faced, he said: 'As we got close to putting it [the car] in the market, uh my friends in India, somewhat distanced themselves from me, otherwise known as distancing yourself from failure and when the car came out, I suddenly felt that I didn't have a friend in the world, and that all the warnings that people had given me were probably going to come true.' But Ratan's strongest urge is to do what is dismissed as undoable and he pursued his dream of an Indian car with unwavering determination. He was undaunted, though his plan to enter the car business was termed as a 'gamble' that was 'widely predicted to drag down its flagship Telco business'. He 'stuck to his guns. Cars are a big part of his ambitious vision for Tata … He wants to show that Indian manufacturing can compete on a world stage,' wrote *The Economist*.

Challenges have always brought out the best in Ratan. He said that the passenger car was an 'investment in building the infrastructure of TELCO'. He added that with the launch of the Indica, the company was simply